

If the digital excludes, talking about Smart cities is merely rhetoric

Intervention by Ginevra Cerrina Feroni, Vice President of the Italian Data Protection Authority
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When thinking about the city of the future, the term smart city is often evoked, which means intelligent city. What does it actually entail? Simplifying to the maximum, one can say that a city is smart to the extent that its urban structure has integrated with information and communication technologies. In other words, the smart city represents the archetype of the application of technological innovation to community life.

Not a science fiction scenario, evoking suggestive "control rooms," but hybrid urban spaces, where the constant flow of data between humans and machines supports strategic decision-making processes. It goes without saying that the current protagonist of the debate is artificial intelligence, along with other technologies such as the Internet of Things (IoT), cloud computing, and 5G. At the heart of all this is the creation of an enormous and unprecedented volume of data, enabled by the ubiquitous and interconnected use of devices and sensors.

The implications are significant. From the reduction and optimization of energy consumption to the ability to report incidents and instantly transmit information to the institutions responsible for intervening. In cities with high tourism rates, for example, it is possible to measure and manage the flows of people entering and exiting. It is obvious that the benefits of a smart city primarily concern the way and degree of enjoyment of citizens' rights.

The promise of an intelligent city is, in fact, the very ambitious goal of improving the qualitative and quantitative level of services: from urban waste disposal to street lighting, from the use of home automation to mobility. Here opens the crucial chapter regarding smart parking systems, the regulation of traffic lights to reduce waiting times for drivers, and the rational management of traffic.

Florence aspires to be among the smartest cities in Italy, so much so that, a few months ago, the municipal administration inaugurated the new hub for mobility management. A technological infrastructure that aims — through an integrated information system of what happens in the city — to ensure, among other things, the overall improvement of traffic. An undoubtedly commendable perspective. It is a pity that, until now, the change has not been perceived. The structural and unresolved problems of urban traffic, unfortunately not improved with the tram system, are well known, especially when two drops of rain fall and the city literally goes into a tailspin, despite its touted smartness.

Finally, it is necessary to clarify a possible misunderstanding. A smart city is not simply a digitized and well-connected city. It is much more. It is a city that improves the lives of its inhabitants, that enables and empowers the rights of individuals and democratic processes, that includes and does not exclude. Technology must be an emancipating tool for rights and freedoms, not a source of new inequalities and discrimination. The digital, if not well governed, risks indeed widening and exacerbating disadvantaged starting conditions. The problem is that of the digital divide, namely those who today, especially among the over 70 population, are unable to open a computer or read an email and, therefore, do not have the opportunity to be a citizen in the true sense. Already today, if you do not have access to the internet, do not own a smartphone, or do not know how to download an app, you may have difficulty scheduling a blood test or renewing a car permit. A state must take care of defending the vulnerable, putting them in a position not to be left behind. Otherwise, talking about digitization becomes mere rhetoric.

There is also the entire issue of personal data protection, which assumes primary importance in the context of "smart cities." Let us think only of the urban furnishings of smart cities, namely the ubiquity of sensors installed in the most disparate contexts, from urban waste collection systems to streetlights, and then energy geolocation, tracking of phone identifiers, intelligent surveillance with cameras and facial recognition systems. All this will become the norm of the urban backdrop and the daily lives of us citizens. The consequence is an incessant collection and processing of personal data of residents or even just transients in the smart city.

In light of these scenarios, the fundamental principles of personal data protection will remain a valuable tool for rebalancing the power dynamics between rulers and the ruled and for ensuring an ethical and constitutionally sustainable development of the cities of the future.